

BJP's allegation that the findings are partisan. Even Congress scion Rahul Gandhi did not absolve Rao of the demolition when in 2007, he had said that the demolition would not have happened had his father, Rajiv, been alive. Since an entire generation of first-time voters was born after December 6, 1992, Ayodhya has limited relevance. Yet, both the BJP and the Congress believe that it still has emotive and electoral appeal. "Even for those who were born after the demolition, what is important to everyone is the right to practise one's religion," says Salman Khurshid, minister of minority affairs.

The BJP's plan is to play up the 'perverse' inclusion of Vajpayee's name. The division of labour within the saffron camp has the VHP and the RSS defending the demolition and

the BJP questioning the credibility of the report and reiterating its commitment to building a temple at Ayodhya. Whichever way they play it, once again Ram rules.

The report has also given Advani fresh legitimacy within the Parivar by shoring up his Hindutva credentials. Advani's ideological somersaults have not been appreciated by the Parivar. A few weeks ago in an exclusive interview to INDIA TODAY, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat had stated that unlike Advani, he does not regret the demolition. An exit plan for the Leader of Opposition had also been worked out. But now with the revival of the politics of Ayodhya, the Sangh hardliners may not be that keen to wish away the poster boy of the movement, leading a senior Congress leader to comment wryly, "I find this party very strange where in order to gain stature you have to be indicted." Of course, it helps when the cause is 'right'. And so Advani is back to his pre-demolition rhetoric to prove his utility to the Parivar once again. "I am proud of my association with the Ayodhya movement and reiterate my commitment to building the Ram Mandir," he said in Parliament.

The secular parties are using this report to bolster their minority appeal. Up for grabs is the Muslim vote. Relieved by the clean chit given to Rao, the Congress has hinted that supplementary charge-sheets could be filed based on the Commission's findings. Both Amar Singh and Mayawati have jumped on to the secular bandwagon. Amar's scuffle with the BJP's S.S. Ahluwalia in Rajya Sabha during the tabling of the report was solely for the Muslim viewers, leading Ahluwalia to quip, "Why are you beating a Sikh for the Muslim vote?" Mayawati too wasted no time in blaming both the BJP and the Congress for the demolition.

Of course, the rather 'timely' leak has helped to disunite the Opposition which had united to take on the Congress on price rise. Taking on the UPA over the Madhu Koda issue was next on the Opposition's agenda. The Congress is hoping to



ADVANI IS LIKELY TO USE THE REPORT TO REVIVE HIS OWN POLITICAL CAREER; SONIA AND SINGH MAY NOT PLAY BALL

Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY Photograph by D. RAVINDER REDDY / www.indiatodayimages.com



6.30-7 pm

The Union Cabinet imposes President's Rule in Uttar Pradesh. Kalyan Singh resigns. Idols placed at the original spot. Construction of makeshift temple begins.

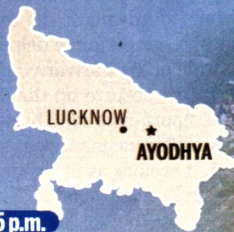
1.15-3.30 p.m.

The DGP requests permission to fire. The chief minister refuses to allow it. First dome collapses after holes in the structure are pulled down. Communal riots break out in Ayodhya.



12.45 p.m.

The paramilitary forces fail to reach the disputed structure after being obstructed by the kar sevaks. The damage continues. The forces cannot communicate with their officers. State police and PAC take no action.



NUMBER OF KAR SEVAKS PRESENT IN AND AROUND AYODHYA 75,000—1.5 lakh

